

ROCK PLANTS

The delicate flowers and foliage of many rock plants belie their tough nature, withstanding the burning sun and harsh winds typical of their alpine habitats. They make excellent plants for the garden, and are perfect for rock and scree gardens, wall crevices, troughs, and pots.

What are rock plants?

The term rock plants includes bulbs and mat- and cushion-forming perennials—many of which are evergreen—as well as dwarf conifers and both evergreen and deciduous shrubs. Some are true alpiners from mountain regions, while others are simply compact plants suitable for rock-garden planting schemes. While some alpiners have specialized needs, many species and cultivars, including aubrietas and geraniums, are easy to grow and thrive in any well-drained soil and sunny site.

True alpiners are found at high altitudes above the tree line on mountains, growing on scree slopes, in short turf, or finding protection from the wind by squeezing into rock crevices. Subalpine plants live below the tree line on rocky slopes or in high pastures or meadows. Most alpiners are compact in habit and frequently deep-rooting, usually with small leaves that are leathery, fleshy, or covered in fine hair.

These adaptations help them survive the drying, high-velocity winds, brilliant, burning sun, and extreme temperature fluctuations of their natural habitats.

Most rock plants grow in areas that have stony soil with rapid drainage, which explains why few can cope with wet soil around the roots, which is experienced at lower altitudes. They also dislike warm, humid summers.

In the wild, high-growing species are insulated from winter cold by a blanket of snow, beneath which they remain dormant at temperatures around 32°F (0°C) until spring. Those environments that mimic conditions in the wild, such as rock gardens, scree and gravel beds, troughs, pots, raised beds, and open frames, are therefore ideal for growing rock plants. You can grow alpiners successfully even in areas where the soil is unsuitable by filling raised beds, pots, and troughs with free-draining soil and horticultural grit.

SIZE CATEGORIES USED WITHIN THIS GROUP		
Large over 6in (15cm)	Medium ————	Small up to 6in (15cm)

Designing with rock plants

One of the major attractions of this group is their diminutive size, which allows you to grow a huge number of different plant types in a relatively confined space.

In a rock garden—as in larger-scale plantings—use small shrubs, such as the highly fragrant *Daphne cneorum* and *D. retusa* or the catkin-bearing *Salix boeckii* and *S. apoda*, to form the structural framework of your design. Miniature conifers, such as *Juniperus communis* ‘Compressa’, provide vertical accents and year-round color, and work well in combination with the contrasting forms of rounded or domed plants, such as the evergreen *Hebe cupressoides* ‘Boughton Dome’ and *Cassiope lycopodioides*. This structure can then be filled in with mat- and cushion-forming plants, such as sandworts (*Arenaria*) or *Dianthus deltoides*,



ABOVE Mediterranean mountains
Recreate a Mediterranean alpine scene with clay pots and pebbles decorating beds that include a range of sedums, hylotelephiums, saxifrages, thymes, and arabis, with clipped boxwood balls providing structure.

LEFT Colorful tapestry
Siting a rock garden on a gentle slope assists rapid drainage, while an open, sunny site is perfect for alpiners. Choose plants with contrasting forms, such as teardrop-shaped, upright conifers and mats of colorful blooms.